



MONKEY BUSINESS

News of The Funky Monkeys, Lynbrook High School Robotics, FIRST® Team 846



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Editor-in-Chief: Brian Rong

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Being A Rookie

Kushal Dugasani (soph.)

When people hear the word “robotics,” they usually picture a group of “nerds” just magically creating a robot with their vast knowledge. And while those are certainly part of the experience, my first year as a rookie taught me that robotics is something much deeper.

When I first joined I was terrified by the people I saw. Everyone seemed to know exactly what they

To me, robotics represents growth, community, and the discovery of a second family.

were doing, operating complex systems, assembling parts, and throwing around terms that sounded completely random to me. I remember standing awkwardly in the

corner during my first meeting, trying not to get in anyone’s way. The workshop buzzed with the whirring of machines and the sharp smell of metal, coolant, and solder. I felt like an outsider looking into someone else’s world. I worried that I would not be smart enough, skilled enough, or confident enough to belong there. But what I did not realize was that every single person on that team had once been in my shoes. They understood the feeling of being overwhelmed, and instead of expecting perfection, they welcomed curiosity.

Slowly, my fear began to fade. Older members took the time to explain tools, teach techniques, and answer even my simplest questions without judgment. These moments might seem small from the outside, but they meant everything to me. They showed me that I was capable of learning and improving, highlighting that being “smart” was not about knowing everything at

see Being A Rookie, page 4

My Experience With Field Elements

Mudit Budhdev (jr.)

This past season, I was selected to be the co-lead for the Field Elements subteam.

My job was to help guide new members in building the official game field for our robot to practice on. Field Elements is an important part of the robot testing process, where we built structures for the robot to score on. The process of building this structure sounded simple at first, but working with a fairly new group

brought a lot more to the table.

Most of the members helping me were new to the tools, so a big part of my role was hands-on teaching: how to measure accurately, how to use a drill safely, how to use different machines properly, and make sure everything was functional before we

see My Experience With Field Elements, page 2

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Field Reset Volunteer

Olivia Yuen (sr.)

Standing in the crowd of multiple teams at the FRC Canadian Pacific Regional, I was full of curiosity and excitement. This was the first ever robotics competition I had ever attended, and flying all the way to Vancouver for our first event of the season made everything feel monumental. The venue buzzed with energy, the bustling of the pits, the echo of the cheering crowds, and people everywhere learning and asking questions about other teams' robots and strategies.

Out of the many engaging activities to do at the competition, being a field reset volunteer quickly became one of my favorites.

During the competitions, I loved being able to see the playing field up close with all the robots, ready to compete.

Standing only a few feet away, I could hear the robots zooming past and bumping around and the vibrations of each intense match through the floor. Talking to the teams while helping them set up was always interesting where they are from. One moment I was chatting with a team from Brazil, and the next with students from Taiwan. It filled me with amazement just how much robotics connected people from all over the world.

Right after the end of each match, I run onto the field, taking the coral, white plastic tubes, off the reef and restoring it back into the human player stations. We would jump to knock the algae, blue inflatable balls,

*see **Field Reset Volunteer**,
page 3*

My Experience With Field Elements, Continued...



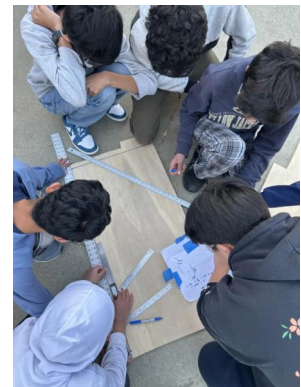
Students working on a wooden part for field elements.

could begin assembling the final structures. We did go through some challenges while building, where, for instance, all the wood on one of the primary builds snapped, and we had to remake it completely.

However, what stood out most to me was watching the team go from unsure to confident in creating a strong base that could be successfully used to test our robot's functionality. It was my first time leading such a large group, and I focused on ensuring that everyone understood their tasks and felt confident working even when I wasn't there. I guided new members through the build

process, answered questions as they came, and helped troubleshoot any problems. Leading field elements taught me a lot about leadership and gave me experience managing a large group.

By the end of the season, we had made significant progress on the field, and the rookies had gained confidence in using tools, following plans, and troubleshooting problems. For any new members who are unsure where to start with Lynbrook Robotics, I highly recommend field elements.



Students cutting out a piece of wood for field elements.



The playing field at the Canadian Pacific Regional.

Field Reset Volunteer, Continued...

out of the barge, an overhead net, with a person on the other side, ready to catch it. I remember I thought of catching the ball as a fun little game. Picking up the screws that fell off robots during the matches almost became a scavenger hunt. During this time, I found myself bonding and forming friendships with the other volunteers around me.

Weeks later at the Aerospace regional, I signed up again as a field reset volunteer with zero hesitation, gaining yet another iconic blue volunteer shirt. This time, I got to take on new responsibilities. I got to help wave the team flags high in the air as the emcee announced the team name and the crowd roared, cheering

as loud as they could and jumping in the stands. In between matches, I would guide the teams in queue to prepare for the match, directing the

*Volunteering was not only fun
but I got to contribute in
helping make the competition
a memorable experience.*

busy traffic of robots. As new volunteers joined, I took on training them, teaching them all the volunteer responsibilities.

Occasionally, I also repumped the algaeas that either got deflated or popped by robots during the thrilling matches. During breaks, I loved socializing with other field reset volunteers from other teams, learning

about what their team does and joking about the sights we had seen each day. Even though we all came from different places and teams, of us all had a fun time, making jokes and laughing together. Being a FRC volunteer pushed me to improve my social skills and allowed me to interact with new people.

Volunteering also reminded me that some things were bigger than the competition itself, these events weren't just about robots, but about friendships and camaraderie. Every now and then I still wear the blue volunteer shirts I got from these competitions, and keep my field reset badge sitting on my shelf like a trophy, reminiscing on the fun moments I had as field reset volunteer.



My Introduction To Machining

Tyler Nagareda (jr.)

When I first joined the team, machining immediately caught my attention. While most of the other areas were digital, machining was hands-on and tangible. I was fascinated by the idea that this was

*These parts were crucial to
testing the robot, and they
taught me the fundamentals
of machining, including
measuring precisely and
reading machinist drawings.*

where concepts became reality.

When the build season began, I started with field elements, cutting plywood and assembling the struc-

tures our robot used for practice.

After getting comfortable with those skills, I moved on to CAM. CAM, or computer aided manufacturing, is the process of turning a CAD design into code that machines can follow to cut out metal. This was where I bridged digital models into metal parts. At first, it was overwhelming as there were feeds, speeds, tool selection, and numerous other small details to consider, but mentors and other students helped guide me through it. Watching a toolpath I created run cleanly for the first time was incredibly rewarding and made me feel like I was truly contributing to the team.

Later in the season, I began working with our CNCs, which are computer controlled mills. These machines use computer instructions (CAM) to cut and drill metal, producing parts with higher precision that can be achieved by hand. Running it for the first time was nerve-wracking; however I will never for-

get the awe of watching it effortlessly slice through metal and turn my program into a functional part.

My personal favorite machine in the shop is our OMIO. It is one of our types of CNC that we currently have. One of my favorite moments was when I completed my first part on my own without the guidance of

*I handled everything from
the CAM, calibrating the
machine, and checking all
of my work to make sure
nothing was overlooked.*

a mentor or teammate.

When the OMIO completed the final pass around the part, it was incredibly rewarding. That moment showed me how much I have progressed and gave me more confid-

see *My Introduction To Machining*, page 3

My Introduction To Machining, Continued...

ence in my later projects.

Machining has taught me far more than how to use tools or operate machines. It has pushed me to solve problems creatively, think outside of the box, and recover quickly from mistakes. Every chal-



The OMIO CNC, one of the most important machines in our shop.

lenge I faced taught me to innovate, a skill that extends well beyond the scope of robotics.



Being A Rookie, Continued...

once, but being willing to ask, fail, try again, and grow as a person.

As the season progressed, robotics stopped being just an after-school activity. It became a place where I felt understood and supported. Long nights at work sessions turned into shared jokes, collective problem-solving, and memories built around both success and frustration.

Robotics taught me that

*The people I once thought
were intimidating became
mentors, teammates, and
eventually close friends.*

community was not something that you found, but something built through patience, trust, and kindness through even the hardest of challenges.

Competitions made that even clearer. I was intrigued by the infinite amount of teams and their unique names. Standing in the pits

surrounded by noise, pressure, and excitement, I saw how every member contributed something valuable. Whether it was driving the robot, scouting teams, wiring electronics, or organizing tools, we moved with a sense of unity.

My rookie year taught me that robotics was far more than building a robot. It's about growing as a person, supporting one another, and finding a community that pushes you to be your best. Robotics taught me more than just technical skills, it helped me build confidence, character, and friendships that will stay with me long after high school ends. And that, to me, is what truly makes robotics special.



Graphic by Brian Rong